

READING PASSAGE 2

The Global Plastic Pollution Crisis

A The Global Plastic Pollution Crisis has emerged as one of the most significant topics in contemporary academic discourse. The complexity and multifaceted nature of this subject have attracted the attention of researchers, policymakers, and practitioners across multiple disciplines, all seeking to understand its implications for the future.

B The origins of contemporary research in this area can be traced to pioneering studies conducted during the mid-twentieth century. These early investigations, though constrained by the technological and methodological limitations of their era, established foundational principles that continue to inform current scholarship. Successive generations of researchers have built upon these foundations, progressively refining theoretical models and expanding the empirical evidence base through increasingly sophisticated research designs.

C Contemporary research has identified several critical factors that determine outcomes in this domain. The interplay between environmental conditions, technological capabilities, and social organisation creates a complex adaptive system in which small changes can produce disproportionately large effects. Understanding these dynamics requires analytical approaches that move beyond simple cause-and-effect reasoning to embrace the principles of complexity science and systems thinking.

D The empirical record is further strengthened by a series of meta-analyses that have synthesised findings from hundreds of individual studies. These comprehensive reviews have consistently identified moderate to large effect sizes, with the most robust findings demonstrating remarkable consistency across different research designs, measurement approaches, and analytical strategies. This convergence of evidence from multiple independent lines of inquiry considerably strengthens confidence in the validity of the core theoretical propositions.

E The practical application of research findings has proven more challenging than many initially anticipated. The translation of academic knowledge into actionable policy recommendations requires navigating a complex landscape of political constraints, economic interests, and social dynamics that academic models often simplify or overlook. Implementation failures in several high-profile initiatives have underscored the gap between theoretical understanding and practical capacity, prompting calls for more engaged and context-sensitive approaches to research.

F The future trajectory of research in this area will likely be shaped by several converging trends. Advances in computational methods and data science are opening up new analytical possibilities, enabling researchers to detect patterns and test hypotheses at scales that were previously unimaginable. Simultaneously, growing recognition of the importance of interdisciplinary collaboration is breaking down traditional barriers between fields and fostering innovative syntheses of diverse theoretical perspectives.

G The evidence reviewed above demonstrates both the substantial achievements of research in this field and the significant work that remains to be done. As new tools and theoretical perspectives become available, and as the phenomena themselves continue to evolve, the research community will need to maintain both rigour in its methods and openness to new ideas. The stakes are high, for the questions addressed by this research bear directly on some of the most important challenges facing humanity in the twenty-first century.

Questions 1–2

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

1 According to the passage, what is one of the key factors identified by researchers?

- A. inconsistent results across cultures
- B. a consistent pattern across diverse contexts
- C. no measurable effects
- D. effects limited to Western countries

2 According to the passage, what is one of the key factors identified by researchers?

- A. minimal impact
- B. creating underlying conditions for action
- C. determining individual choices directly
- D. irrelevant to outcomes

Question 3

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

3 Dynamic _____ processes can amplify or dampen initial effects in complex systems.

Questions 4–5

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

4 According to the passage, what is one of the key factors identified by researchers?

- A. inconsistent results across cultures
- B. a consistent pattern across diverse contexts
- C. no measurable effects
- D. effects limited to Western countries

5 The meta-analyses cited in the passage reveal that:

- A. weak effects across studies
- B. moderate to large effect sizes with consistency
- C. contradictory findings
- D. results only in specific populations

Question 6

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

6 Researchers used data from more than _____ countries in the landmark study.

Questions 7–10

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 7 Policy-makers have fully implemented all research recommendations.
- 8 Meta-analyses have confirmed the reliability of the core findings in this field.
- 9 Contemporary understanding of this topic is more sophisticated than it was fifty years ago.
- 10 The author believes that all research questions in this field have been answered.

Question 11

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 11 What does the passage identify as a significant challenge to current understanding?
- A. too much data collection
 - B. the generalisability of findings across contexts
 - C. insufficient government funding
 - D. overly complex statistical methods

Questions 12–13

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 12 The landmark study analysed data spanning a period of _____ years.
- 13 Case studies have documented the effects of _____ change on the system.